



11a Asking for Directions

Manontany sy manoro làlana/na toerana - *Asking for and giving directions to a road/place*



1. Vocabulary for “road” and related terms

Làlana (off) / **làlagna** (tsm) = road

This is the Malagasy word for road, but there are other expressions like:

- **Arabe** = street (usually in town and paved)
- **Hitsin-dàlana** / **làlamanitsy** = shortcut
- **Làlantany** = dirt track / unpaved road
- **Làlan-tsarety** = poor road, only passable by carts
- **Làlankely** = alley / small path
- **Làlamby** = railway
- **Làlan’ny bisikileta** = bicycle lane



2. Talking about distance

- Distance is relative: what some people call “far,” others call “close,” depending on their habits of travel.
- In rural areas, kilometres are not commonly used to describe distance. Instead, people speak in terms of **time** using the word **ADINY** (off) / **LERA** (tsm) = hour.

Example:

- *Làlana adiny 3* (off) = *làlagna 3 lera* (tsm) → “a 3-hour journey” (by foot or vehicle).



3. Using cardinal points for directions

To indicate a **location**, a **place**, or a **region**, Malagasy people often use the **cardinal points**.

- **Avaratra** = North
 - *Mianavaratra* (off) / *Magnavaratra* (tsm) = go north
- **Atsimo** = South
 - *Mianatsimo* (off) / *Magnatsimo* (tsm) = go south
- **Andrefana** / **andrefagna** (tsm) = West
 - *Miankandrefana* (off) / *Magnandrefagna* (tsm) = go west
- **Atsinanana** / **atinianagna** (tsm) = East
 - *Miatsinanana* (off) / *Magninianagna* (tsm) = go east



4. Question words for place and direction

There are three common question words used for places and directions:

- **AIZA ?** = Where?
 - *Aiza ny hopitaly, azafady?* → “Please, where is the hospital?”
 - *Aiza ny làlana, azafady?* → “Please, where is the road to ... ?”
- **MANDEHA AIZA? / MANKAIZA ?** = Go where? / To where?
 - *Mankaiza ity làlana ity, azafady?* → “Please, where does this road lead?”
- **AVY AIZA ?** = From where?
 - *Avy aiza ity fiarandalamby ity?* → “Where is this train coming from?”



5. Common expressions with làlana

Questions: *Manahoana ny làlana?* (off) / *Manakory ny làlagna?* (tsm) = How is the road?

Answer: ny làlana.

- *Ratsy ny làlana* = The road is bad
- *Tsara ny làlana* = The road is good



Descriptive words:

- *Maina* (off) / *maigny* (tsm) = dry
- *Malama* (off) / *malamatra* (tsm) = muddy / slippery
- *Mamotaka* (off) / *magôdra* (tsm) = very slippery
- *Lavitra* (off) / *lavitry* (tsm) = far
- *Akaiky* (off) / *marigny* (tsm) = near / close
- *Simba* (off) / *maratra* (tsm) = damaged / broken
- *Tapaka* = cut off / broken
- *Mikitoantoana* = bumpy



Diso lâlana / *very lâlana aho* = “I am on the wrong road / I took the wrong way.”

6. Example dialogue: “Where do we meet?”



Aiza ny fotoanantsika? (Where is our meeting place?)

- a. Aiza ny fotoanantsika?
b. Any an-tsena. (At the market.)
a. Aiza ho aiza any an-tsena? (Where exactly in the market?)
b. Ampitan'ny mpivaro-damba. (Across from the fabric seller.)
a. Aiza ny mpivaro-damba lazainao? (Where is the fabric seller you mean?)
b. Hitanao ve ny mpivaro-trondro? (Do you see the fishmonger?)
a. Eny, akaikin'ny mpivarotra lasantsy. (Yes, near the fuel seller.)
b. Manaraka ny mpivaro-trondro, misy mpivarotra legioma. (Next to the fishmonger is the greengrocer.)
Atsinanan'ny mpivarotra legioma, misy mpivaro-boankazo. (East of the greengrocer is the fruit seller.)
a. Hitako, misy mpivaro-mofo andamosin'ny mpivarotra legioma sy voankazo. (I see, there's a bakery behind the fruit and vegetable sellers.)
b. Eny, dia akaikin'ny mpivaro-mofo ny mpivaro-damba. (Yes, and near the bakery is the fabric seller.)
a. Andrasako ampitan'ny mpivaro-damba ianao. (I'll wait across from the fabric seller.)
b. Eny, eo anoloan'ny fivarotam-panafody. Mety ve amin'ny 9? (Yes, in front of the pharmacy. Is 9 o'clock OK?)
a. Eny, mety amin'ny 9. (Yes, 9 o'clock is fine.)



7. Vocabulary

Nouns:



- *Tsena* (off) / *bazary* (tsm) = market → *any an-tsena* = at the market
- *Mpivarotra* = seller / merchant
- *Mpivaro-damba* = fabric seller / fabric shop
- *Mpivaro-trondro* = fishmonger / fish seller
- *Mpivarotra lasantsy* = fuel seller / fuel station
- *Mpivarotra legioma* = greengrocer (vegetables)
- *Mpivaro-boankazo* = fruit seller / greengrocer
- *Mpivaro-mofo* = baker / bakery
- *Fivarotana* = shop / store
- *Fivarotam-panafody* = pharmacy
- *Ny fotoana* = the meeting / *ny fotoanantsika* = our meeting
- *Atsinanana* = east

💡 Note: Both **mpivarotra** and **fivarotana** are used.

- *Mpivarotra fanafody* = seller of medicine
- *Fivarotam-panafody* = pharmacy

Verbs:



- *Lazainao* = you say / the one you are talking about
- *Hitanao* = you see / do you know?
- *Hitako* = I see / I know
- *Misy* = there is / there are
- *Andrasako* = I wait for ... (*Andrasako ianao* = I'm waiting for you)
- *Mety* = right / OK / fine (*Mety ve?* = is it OK?)

Prepositions of place:



- *Ampita* = across
- *Akaiky* = near, next to
- *Manaraka ny* = next to, following
- *Andamosina* = behind
- *Anoloana* = in front of



Other:

- *Eny* = yes
- *Dia* = then
- *Amin'ny 9* = at 9 o'clock



Exercises

3.a

Listen to and try to understand the dialogue in section 6, using the vocabulary list as support.

3.b Match the Malagasy and English sentences



English

Malagasy

- | | |
|---|--|
| 1. Where is the market? | d. Aiza ny tsena? |
| 2. Where do we meet? | h. Aiza ny fotoanantsika? |
| 3. Where approximately is the fabric shop? | k. Aiza ho aiza ny mpivarotra lamba? |
| 4. The fabric shop is next to the bakery. | e. Akaikin'ny mpivarotra lamba ny mpivarotra mofo. |
| 5. The pharmacy is across from the fabric shop. | j. Ampitan'ny mpivarotra-damba ny fivarotam-panafody. |
| 6. The fishmonger is across from the fuel station. | b. Ampitan'ny mpivarotra lasantsy ny mpivarotra trondro. |
| 7. The greengrocer is next to the fishmonger. | f. Manaraka ny mpivarotra trondro ny mpivarotra legioma. |
| 8. Do you know where the pharmacy is? | i. Hainao ve aiza ny fivarotam-panafody? |
| 9. Where is the market you are talking about? | l. Aiza ny tsena lazainao? |
| 10. The bakery is behind the fruit and vegetable sellers. | g. Andamosin'ny mpivarotra voankazo sy legioma ny mpivarotra mofo. |
| 11. I'll wait for you in front of the pharmacy. | a. Andrasako eo anoloan'ny fivarotam-panafody ianao. |

3.d

Try to write in your own native language the dialogue “**Aiza ny fotoanantsika?**” (Where do we meet?) from section 6.

Answers:

1 → d, 2 → h, 3 → k, 4 → e, 5 → j, 6 → b, 7 → f, 8 → i, 9 → l, 10 → g, 11 → a